

The Adaptive Organization

*A leadership guide to the system that builds business agility
business agility*



CINCYDELIVER 2026 · BRIAN LINK · PRACTICAL AGILIST

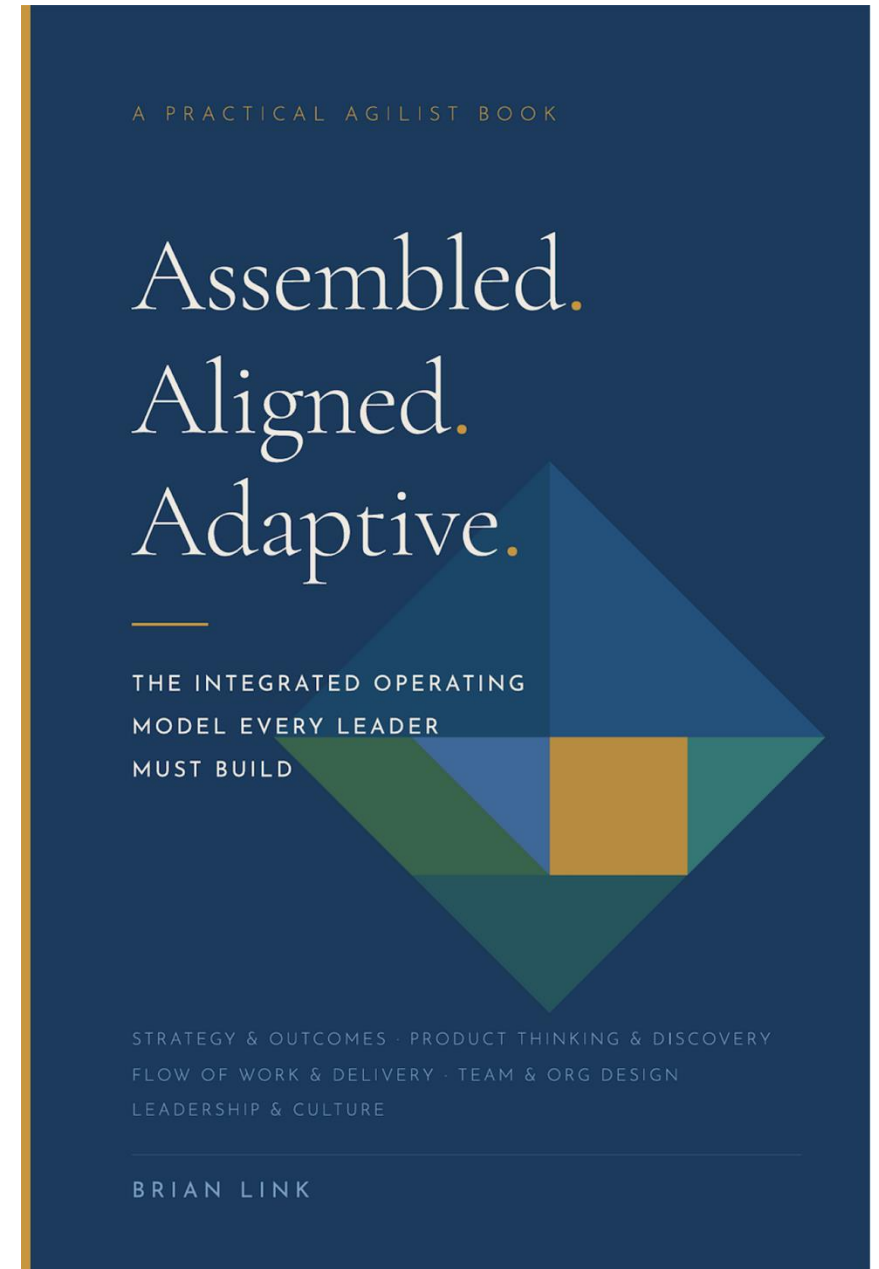
INTRODUCTION

Hi. I'm Brian Link.

I'm an Enterprise Agile Coach, working at Huntington Bank on a transformation of 266 teams and 22,000 people.

Two years ago, I launched my first book “The Practical Agilist Guidebook” right here at this event.

Today I'd love to introduce you the ideas in my second book and tell you why I'm so passionate about this topic.



You've felt hope and skepticism in the same same breath.

The “becoming more agile” slide goes up. You can see the problems it's meant to solve — and you've watched initiatives like this before.

That skepticism is earned.

Real progress stalls, and the culture feels too stubborn to move. People aren't the problem. You changed the parts and never the way they work together.

Assembled. Aligned. Adaptive. names why and shows you what to build instead.

***“Build the environment where teams can
can succeed.”***

We've said it for more than twenty years. Always the right idea. Never enough — because no one ever says exactly **how**.

“The environment” means a culture shift for leaders.

It is the operating model that makes a transformation successful.

You build it the slow way — through new daily behaviors in the leaders who own delivery, and the leaders above them. You've taught the teams. You might even have execs on board. What almost no one has focused on are the behaviors **above the team** — managers and directors running the *old playbook* inside the new system.

That's where transformations quietly stall. The org settles into a comfortable new normal and calls it progress.

That's the failure. It just doesn't look like one.

THE PROBLEM

Five dysfunctions that show up everywhere

Not failures of individuals. Failures of the system.

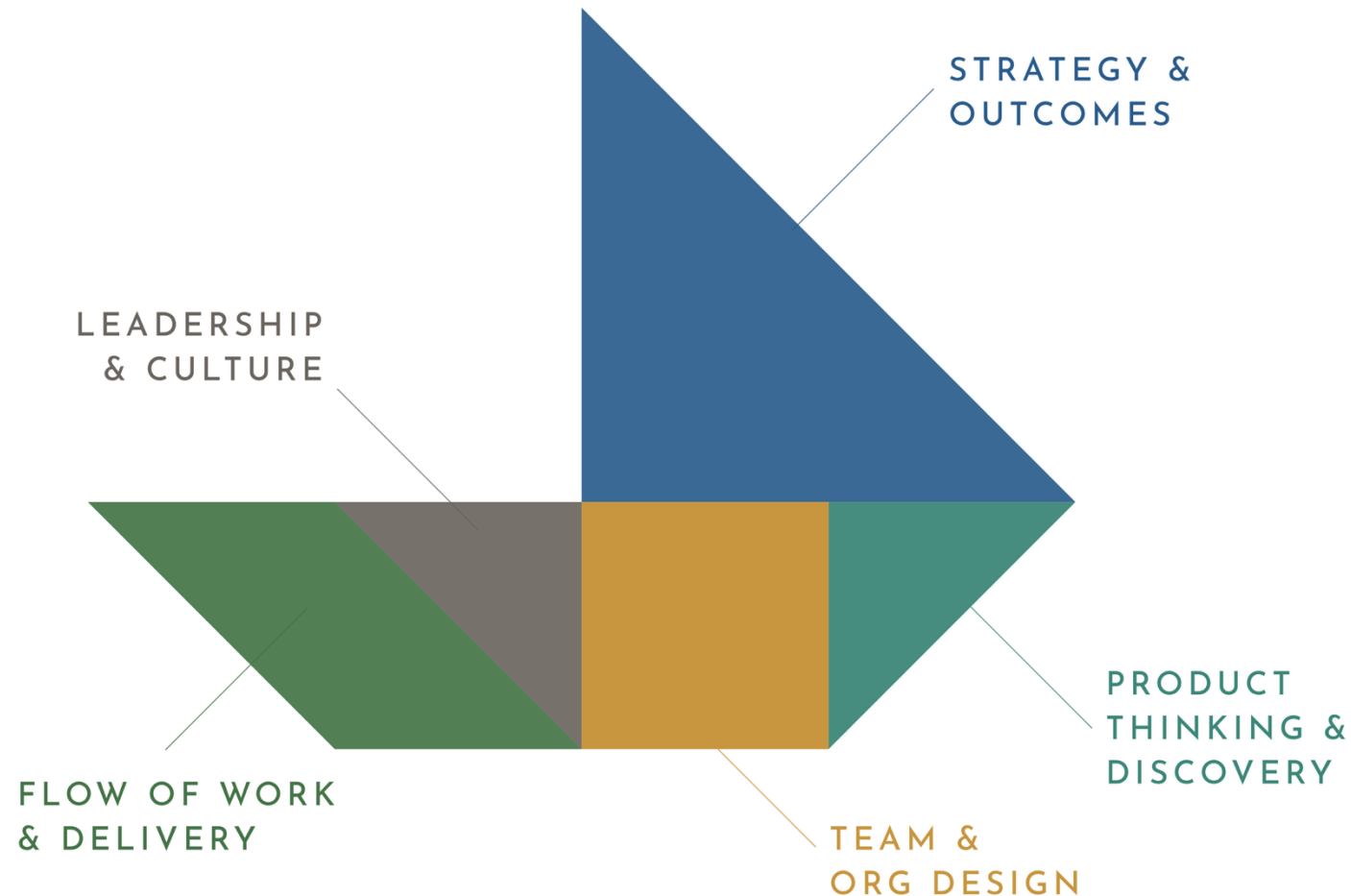


The same five, every time

- 1 Strategy is disconnected from the work** Goal lists dressed as strategy — big rocks, five pillars, OKRs — with no diagnosis and no link to a customer problem.
- 2 Output is rewarded over outcomes** Features shipped, projects closed, vanity metrics — convincing everyone the system works until a more adaptive competitor proves it doesn't.
- 3 Work moves too slowly through the system** Read as a capacity problem; it's system friction — handoffs, approvals, batches in queues. The biggest batch is the annual budget.
- 4 Structure works against the strategy** Org charts drawn around function and reporting history, not around how value reaches a customer. Nobody owns a problem end to end.
- 5 Leaders manage work instead of designing systems** Directing tasks and clearing escalations signals nothing moves without the leader's judgment. The hardest dysfunction to see from the inside.

THE ADAPTIVE ORGANIZATION OPERATING MODEL

Five pieces. One system.



PART 1: Strategy & Outcomes

Are we clear about what problems we're solving — and how we'll know we've solved them?

PART 2: Product Thinking & Discovery

Are we solving the right problem, at the right time, for a real customer, in a meaningful way?

PART 3: Flow of Work & Delivery

How much sooner can we turn learning into customer value?

PART 4: Team & Org Design

Is our organization structured to enable flow and learning?

PART 5: Leadership & Culture

Are leaders creating the conditions for ownership and learning to thrive?

THE INTERDEPENDENCE IS THE ARGUMENT

Each piece is necessary. None is sufficient.



Strategy without product thinking

→ confident execution of the wrong solutions.

Product thinking without flow

→ great discoveries that reach customers too late.

Flow without the right org design

→ faster teams whose work still waits on everyone else.

Any of it without aligned leadership

→ reverts within a year to whatever the culture was before.

This is why partial transformations fail — not because the piece was wrong, but because it was never enough.

A QUICK TOUR

The five parts, up close

*Let's explore the Adaptive Organization Operating Model
...then diagnose your organization!*



FIVE PARTS AT A GLANCE



PART 1

Strategy & Outcomes

Rumelt + Doerr

Real strategy is diagnosis, a guiding policy, and coherent action — and the nerve to say what you won't do.



PART 2

Product Thinking & Discovery

Perri + Cagan

The build trap: shipping features mistaken for creating value. Escaping it is a leadership choice about what gets rewarded.



PART 3

Flow of Work & Delivery

Goldratt + Kersten

You can fill a building with talented people and still deliver slowly — the system creates drag that has nothing to do with effort.



PART 4

Team & Org Design

Conway + Galbraith

The org chart is a product-architecture decision most companies make by accident.



PART 5

Leadership & Culture

Marquet + Kotter

Push decisions to where the information lives. Safety is the precondition every other layer depends on.

WHICH PART IS YOUR CHALLENGE?



PART 1

Strategy & Outcomes

Is your vision clear enough to act on? Is the real problem honestly diagnosed, or just named as goals? Do your OKRs measure outcomes, or read like a to-do list?



PART 2

Product Thinking & Discovery

Are outputs rewarded more than outcomes? Are product bets tied to real customer problems? Do you learn from customers continuously, or only at the start?



PART 3

Flow of Work & Delivery

When work slows, do you add people or find the constraint? How long does an idea take to reach a customer? Do approvals and big batches pile up in queues?



PART 4

Team & Org Design

Was your org chart designed, or just inherited? Do dedicated product teams own the entire value delivery? Can a team ship without waiting on three others?



PART 5

Leadership & Culture

Do your days go to approving and escalating, or setting intent? Can people admit a mistake without fear? Do the people closest to the work get to make the call?

Diagnose your own org

- 1** **Pick which of the 5 layers your table will discuss. Write it on the table tent.** If you'd rather talk about something else, move to a different table (even in middle of convo)
- 2** **Use stickies to build two lists: anti-patterns (behaviors that break or block)** Say them out loud to each other because it will help others to think of things too.
- 3** **Then pair the anti-pattern with a supportive behavior.** For every anti-pattern (what leaders do that breaks this layer), write the better behavior a leader should start doing instead.

EXAMPLES 12+ OKRs that read like a to-do list → name the few outcomes that matter, and say no to the rest.

A roadmap full of features with no customer contact → go talk to real customers this week, and write down what you heard.

Think as a group first. There's a copy of the book on your table — if someone wants to look for ideas to bring back, flip to your part or the summary in the back.

Discuss

10 minutes · anti-patterns + positive leadership behaviors



BRINGING IT BACK TOGETHER

What you found — and what it means

*Your ideas, connected to the voices who named them —
and the daily behavior each layer asks of leaders.*



Strategy & Outcomes



Rumelt *Real strategy is diagnosis, a guiding policy, and coherent action — and the nerve to say what you won't do.*

STOP	presenting a goal list as strategy — five pillars, an initiative parade, a long OKR list — with no diagnosis underneath
START	naming the diagnosis first — one honest sentence about why you're not already there — then a guiding policy people can decide by
MODEL	saying no out loud, and naming the diagnosis the idea didn't address — teams learn the strategy from what you refuse
OFTEN MISSED	A new priority lands in week three. Four teams quietly lose people, and nobody moves their dates. That isn't a resourcing problem — it's a strategy problem.

Product Thinking & Discovery



Perri *The build trap: shipping features mistaken for creating value. Escaping it is a leadership choice about what gets rewarded.*

STOP	arriving at the product review with the solution already in your head — the team becomes order-takers
START	handing over the problem and the authority, then asking one question every week: what did you learn from customers?
MODEL	celebrating what you decided not to build, and saying why — teams optimize for whatever leaders applaud
OFTEN MISSED	“We can’t talk to customers” is almost never a team problem. It’s a political one — sales, legal, compliance — and only a leader can clear the path.

Flow of Work & Delivery



Goldratt *You can fill a building with talented people and still deliver slowly — the system creates drag that has nothing to do with effort.*

- | | |
|---------------------|---|
| STOP | when delivery feels slow, asking why the team isn't working faster — that question has never once found a constraint |
| START | drawing the map instead: every step, every wait state, and the ratio of active time to total elapsed time |
| MODEL | pricing the delay before asking for the fix — “this release window costs us \$50K a month” beats any process argument |
| OFTEN MISSED | Every wait state has an owner — a release window set by an ops team, an approval gate added after an incident nobody remembers. Naming who owns it is what makes it changeable. |

Team & Org Design



Conway *The org chart is a product-architecture decision most companies make by accident.*

STOP

the reorg that changes who reports to whom and nothing about how work actually moves

START

treating every dependency as a design decision to revisit, not a constraint to manage around

MODEL

putting one question on the quarterly calendar: are we still structured for the work we're actually doing?

OFTEN MISSED

Your new structure is still being graded by last year's individual performance review. Rewards is what transformations change last, if ever — and it decides whether the structure survives.

Leadership & Culture



Marquet *Push decisions to where the information lives. Safety is the precondition every other layer depends on.*

STOP	asking a question and then answering it yourself — the team learns that questions here aren't invitations
START	"I intend to..." — the team states what they'll do, and your job is to say "very well" and mean it
MODEL	saying "I don't know — what do you think?" to people who expect you to be certain
OFTEN MISSED	The most dangerous safety-killing behavior looks like helpfulness. Your casual "have you thought about..." lands on the team as "the boss said we need to."

WHERE TO BEGIN

The adaptive organization starts with the adaptive leader.

Transformation isn't something you do *to* teams. They work inside a system you design — through what you measure, reward, govern, and model every day.

Take one team. Find the single layer most constraining it. Fix the root cause, not cause, not the symptom. Then do it again — until the model becomes an instinct an instinct you lead from.

ONE MORE THING

The strongest contributor at each table...

...keeps the book. And I'll sign it.

Everyone else: the free book summary — the whole model in one download — is yours at adaptbook.co.

Assembled. Aligned. Adaptive.

The integrated operating model every leader must build.

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